because the reality it is supposed to represent is complicated. Take, for example, the truth about nations. It is difficult to grasp that the nation to which one belongs is an intersubjective entity that exists only in our collective imagination. You rarely hear politicians say such things in their political speeches. It is far easier to believe that our nation is God's chosen people, entrusted by the Creator with some special mission. This simple story has been repeatedly told by countless politicians from Israel to Iran and from the United States to Russia.

Second, the truth is often painful and disturbing, and if we try to make it more comforting and flattering, it will no longer be the truth. In contrast, fiction is highly malleable. The history of every nation contains some dark episodes that citizens don't like to acknowledge and remember. An Israeli politician who in her election speeches details the miseries inflicted on Palestinian civilians by the Israeli occupation is unlikely to get many votes. In contrast, a politician who builds a national myth by ignoring uncomfortable facts, focusing on glorious moments in the Jewish past and embellishing reality wherever necessary may well sweep to power. That's the case not just in Israel but in all countries. How many Italians or Indians want to hear the unblemished truth about their nations? An uncompromising adherence to the truth is essential for scientific progress, and it is also an admirable spiritual practice, but it is not a winning political strategy.

Already in his *Republic,* Plato imagined that the constitution of his utopian state would be based on 'the noble lie' – a fictional story about the origin of the social order, one that secures the citizens' loyalty and prevents them from questioning the constitution. Citizens should be told, Plato wrote, that they were all born out of the earth, that the land is their mother and that they therefore owe filial loyalty to the motherland. They should further be told that when they were conceived, the gods intermingled different metals – gold, silver, bronze and iron – into them, which justifies a natural hierarchy between golden rulers and bronze servants. While Plato's utopia was never realised in practice, numerous polities through the ages told their inhabitants variations of this noble lie.

Plato's noble lie notwithstanding, we should not conclude that all politicians are liars or that all national histories are deceptions. The choice isn't simply between telling the truth and lying. There is a third option. Telling a fictional story is lying only when you pretend that the story is a true representation of reality. Telling a fictional story isn't lying when you